2. AI Image Generation Prompts (Stable Diffusion, DALL·E/Sora, Midjourney, Leonardo)

High-quality visuals are crucial for TikToks and Reels, whether as video footage or images to include in your edits. This cheat sheet covers how to prompt various AI tools to create images or short video clips. We'll look at **Stable Diffusion**, **OpenAI's image generation in ChatGPT (DALL·E 3) and Sora (text-to-video)**, **Midjourney**, and **Leonardo AI**. Knowing each tool's quirks and parameters will help you get the best results. *All examples assume a vertical 9:16 format appropriate for phones.* ▼

Stable Diffusion (SD) Prompting

What it is: Stable Diffusion is an open-source *text-to-image diffusion model* that generates images by iteratively refining random noise to match your promptzapier.com. It's highly flexible and can be self-hosted or used via tools (Automatic1111 GUI, etc.). SD has many community-trained models for different styles (realistic, anime, etc.).

How to use it: You typically provide a text prompt and can adjust settings like *resolution, number of inference steps, guidance scale (CFG)*, and even *negative prompts*. Stable Diffusion's default model (v1.x) was 512×512 pixels trained, but you can set custom resolutions/aspect ratios. For TikTok/Reels, use a **portrait aspect ratio** (e.g. 9:16). Many SD interfaces let you specify width and height manually. *For example, 576x1024 or 640x1536 pixels are close to 9:16 ratioreddit.com.* Keep in mind that very high resolutions might require more VRAM or produce odd results, so you might generate at a moderate size and upscale later.

- **Prompt structure:** A good SD prompt often contains a **subject** + **modifiers**. Think of including: **medium** (photo, painting, 3D render, etc.), **style/genre** (cyberpunk, baroque, cartoon, etc.), **artists or sources** (if desired, e.g. "in the style of Monet" or "trending on ArtStation"), **lighting** (soft glow, studio lighting, golden hour), **colors or mood**, and **other descriptors** (highly detailed, dramatic, **4K**).
    - *Example:* "**A futuristic skyline at night** – neon lights reflecting on wet streets, **cinematic 35mm photography**, ultra-detailed, **cyberpunk artstyle**, volumetric fog, high contrast, **sharp focus**." This paints a clear picture for the AI. You can see how adding elements iteratively refines the outputstable-diffusion-art.comstable-diffusion-art.com.
- **Negative prompts:** These are a powerful feature in Stable Diffusion to tell the AI what *not* to generate. For instance, you might add `--neg "blurry, low quality, people"` to avoid those aspects, depending on the interface (Automatic1111 uses a separate negative prompt field). **Negative prompts became essential for SD v2** to get good resultsstable-diffusion-art.com. Even with SDXL or v1.5, they help reduce unwanted artifacts (e.g. extra limbs, text). Common negative terms include things like "ugly, out of focus, watermark, text, deformed hands," etc. Adding a basic negative prompt like *"disfigured, deformed, ugly"* often either helps or doesn't hurtstable-diffusion-art.com, so it's a good default.
- **Iterate with Seeds:** Each SD generation starts with random noise, meaning the same prompt can yield different results every timezapier.com. If you get a result you love, note the **seed** number (most UIs show it) – using the same seed with the same prompt will reproduce that image. You can also reuse a seed and alter the prompt slightly to maintain some consistency across images. This is useful for creating a series of images with the same style or character. Many UIs allow setting a seed manuallymidjourneysref.com.

- **Example prompt (Stable Diffusion):**
  *"Portrait of a **street dancer** mid-motion, <u>photorealistic photograph</u>, nighttime city alley backdrop, **soft studio lighting** on subject, **bokeh** background, 85mm lens – **high detail**, vibrant colors. --neg "motion blur, out of focus, grainy"."*
  This prompt describes a clear subject (street dancer) and adds style cues (photorealistic, lens type for depth of field, etc.). The negative prompt tries to eliminate motion blur since we want a sharp action shot. If using an SD UI, you'd put the negative part in the negative prompt box. The result should be a crisp vertical shot suitable for a Reel cover or cutscene.

- **Tip: Less can be more** in SD prompts. Including too many keywords can confuse the AI or muddy the style. It's often recommended to start simple and then add one or two words at a time to see their effect. For example, first get a base image of "a street dancer in a city alley at night" then gradually introduce "photorealistic", then lighting, etc., generating a batch at each step to pick the best. This iterative building ensures you understand what each modifier does.

- **Advanced:** Stable Diffusion allows **custom models** and **ControlNet**. Custom models (like anime models, realism models) can be loaded to dramatically change output style without changing your prompt much. **Leonardo AI** (covered below) actually offers some of these models built-in. **ControlNet** is an extension that lets you guide composition (by providing a pose sketch, depth map, etc.). If you have access to it (Leonardo has a "ControlNet Suite", or Automatic1111 extension), you can ensure, say, your generated dancer matches a specific pose or that your scene follows a layout. This is great for consistency if you need the same character in multiple images or want precise framing.